

Bank of Leeds Strategic Tourism Proposal

York Railway Heritage Festival

A Winter Railway Celebration at the National Railway Museum and Across York's Historic Rail Network

Prepared for:

Bank of Leeds – Tourism, Heritage & Cultural Investment Division

Investment Classification:

Tourism Event / Heritage Economy / Railway Infrastructure / York Visitor Economy

Proposed Investment:

£5 million launch programme

Annual Operating Budget:

£1–2 million

Event Format:

Annual weekend festival

February (late winter / half-term period)

Executive Summary

The Bank of Leeds proposes the creation of:

York Railway Heritage Festival

A major annual railway festival based around the **National Railway Museum, York**, combining:

- historic locomotives,
- steam train experiences,
- diesel and electric heritage trains,
- luxury dining carriages,
- railway exhibitions,
- engineering demonstrations,
- heritage journeys across Yorkshire.

The festival would position York as:

"The railway capital of Britain for one weekend every February."

The National Railway Museum already provides the ideal anchor location. It houses one of the world's most important railway collections, including iconic locomotives and historic rolling stock, and attracts hundreds of thousands of visitors annually.

York also already has a strong railway tourism ecosystem, with heritage operators such as the North Yorkshire Moors Railway running specialist events and gala experiences.

The proposal is to create a winter equivalent of major international transport festivals:

- Goodwood Festival of Speed (motoring)
- Edinburgh Festival (culture)
- Munich Oktoberfest (seasonal identity)

but focused on Britain's railway heritage.

Strategic Vision

"The Great Yorkshire Railway Weekend"

Every February:

York becomes the centre of global railway heritage.

The festival would combine:

National Railway Museum

The exhibition hub.

York Station

The arrival gateway.

Yorkshire Railway Routes

The experience.

Event Structure

Three-Day Festival

Friday–Sunday

February

Festival Zone 1

National Railway Museum Grand Exhibition

Location:

National Railway Museum, York

Events:

- locomotive displays,
 - railway engineering demonstrations,
 - historic carriage tours,
 - talks by railway historians,
 - model railway exhibitions.
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Special temporary exhibitions:

"200 Years of British Railways"

"The Golden Age of Steam"

"The Future Railway"

Festival Zone 2

Heritage Train Experiences

The core commercial opportunity.

Visitors purchase tickets for:

The Yorkshire Steam Explorer

Route:

York

↓

Harrogate

↓

Leeds

↓

Yorkshire countryside

The Dales Explorer

Route:

York

↓

Skipton

↓

Settle

The Coast Explorer

Route:

York

↓

Scarborough

The Moorland Steam Express

Partner operation:

North Yorkshire Moors Railway.

Train Experiences

Standard Heritage Ticket

£75/person

Includes:

- return journey,
 - museum entry,
 - festival access.
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Premium Dining Train

£250/person

Includes:

- steam locomotive,
 - Pullman-style carriage,
 - Yorkshire food,
 - wine pairing.
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First-Class Railway Weekend

£750/person

Includes:

- hotel,
 - multiple journeys,
 - dinners,
 - exclusive access.
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Festival Zone 3

York Railway Quarter

Transform York city centre.

Participating:

- hotels,
 - pubs,
 - restaurants,
 - shops.
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Create:

Railway Passport

Visitors receive discounts:

- accommodation,
 - food,
 - attractions.
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Investment Requirement

Initial Capital

£5 million

Breakdown

Investment	Cost
Event infrastructure	£1.5m
Marketing campaign	£1m
Rolling stock partnerships	£1m
Digital ticketing platform	£500k
York city promotion	£500k
Contingency	£500k

Annual Operating Costs

Approximately:

£1.5 million/year

Includes:

- staffing,
 - marketing,
 - logistics,
 - security,
 - partnerships.
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Visitor Forecast

Year 1

50,000 visitors

Year 5

150,000 visitors

Mature Event

250,000 visitors

Financial Model

Ticket Revenue

150,000 visitors

Average spend:

£75

Revenue:

£11.25 million

Premium Experiences

20,000 customers

Average spend:

£200

Revenue:

£4 million

Food & Retail

Visitor spending:

£50 average

Revenue:

£7.5 million

Total Festival Economy

At maturity:

£20–25 million annually

Wider York Economic Impact

Visitors spend on:

- hotels,
 - restaurants,
 - taxis,
 - attractions,
 - shopping.
-

Estimated economic multiplier:

2–3x

Potential York economic impact:

£40–60 million annually

Employment Impact

Event Employment

Temporary:

500 jobs

Permanent Tourism Jobs

Hotels:

Restaurants:

Retail:

Rail services:

Estimated:

200–300 permanent jobs

Bank of Leeds Role

The Bank of Leeds would act as:

Founder Sponsor

Providing:

- launch capital,
 - commercial coordination,
 - tourism partnerships.
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Create:

York Railway Festival Company Ltd

Ownership:

Partner	Share
Bank of Leeds	40%
National Railway Museum partnership	20%

Partner	Share
York tourism sector	20%
Private investors	20%

Revenue Streams

Ticketing

Primary income.

Sponsorship

Potential partners:

- railway manufacturers,
 - engineering companies,
 - transport companies.
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Corporate Events

Premium railway experiences.

Broadcasting

Potential:

- BBC,
 - streaming platforms,
 - documentary rights.
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Why February?

February is strategically attractive.

Problems:

York tourism is highly seasonal.

Summer:

crowded.

Winter:

lower visitor numbers.

The festival creates:

A winter tourism anchor.

Benefits:

- fills hotels,
 - supports restaurants,
 - creates repeat visitors.
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Comparison With Existing Events

The National Railway Museum already runs family and railway-themed events, including February programming, demonstrating that the museum can attract visitors outside peak summer months.

The proposal scales this into a nationally significant festival.

Long-Term Vision

Year 5

York becomes:

"Britain's railway weekend destination."

Year 10

International railway tourism.

Target visitors:

- United States
 - Japan
 - Germany
 - Netherlands
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Strategic Benefits for Yorkshire

1. Strengthens York's Tourism Economy

Creates a reason to visit outside summer.

2. Supports Railway Heritage

Provides income for:

- restoration,
 - preservation,
 - heritage operators.
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3. Promotes Yorkshire

Creates a recognisable annual event.

4. Connects Yorkshire Towns

Visitors travel across:

- York,
 - Leeds,
 - Harrogate,
 - Scarborough,
 - North Yorkshire Moors.
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Final Recommendation

The Bank of Leeds should establish:

York Railway Heritage Festival

with:

£5 million launch investment

and develop it into an annual:

£50 million Yorkshire tourism event.

Final Investment Thesis

York is already Britain's railway city.

The opportunity is to turn that history into an economic asset.

The vision:

"One weekend every February, the world's railway enthusiasts come to York."

A Bank of Leeds-backed railway festival would transform dormant winter tourism capacity into a major cultural and economic event while reinforcing York's position as the historic home of British railways.